DOMAIN STATEMENT

We are interested in enhancing language learning and communication taking place in the workplace with mutual learning between international co-workers.

DOMAIN EXPERTS / LOCATION

- Onboarding HR staff???
- Work / Corporate Trainers

Interview Guide: Coworkers Supporting a Colleague with Limited Language Proficiency

(Native English Speakers)

PEOPLE TO INTERVIEW

- **Speaks a second language**
- **International students**
- **Graduate students who fit the above**
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Warm-up / context

1. Can you tell me about a time you worked closely with a coworker who had a language barrier? What was that like day-to-day?
2. How did you first realize you needed to adjust how you communicate with them?

Current experience helping

1. Walk me through a recent moment where you had to explain something work-related to them. What did you do — slow down, use gestures, write it out, use a translation app?
2. How much extra time or effort does it typically take you to communicate something compared to with other coworkers?
3. Do you feel equipped to help them, or do you feel like you're guessing/improvising most of the time?
4. Has miscommunication with them ever caused a real problem — a mistake, a missed deadline, confusion in a task? Can you describe it?

Emotional / social dynamics

1. How do you feel in the moment when communication breaks down — frustrated, patient, unsure, something else?

2. Do you ever feel responsible for "carrying" the communication load in the team? Is that fair, in your view?
3. Have you noticed the person avoiding asking questions or pulling back from group conversations? How does that affect the team?
4. Do other coworkers share the responsibility of helping, or does it tend to fall on one or two people (maybe you)?

Team/group setting specifically

1. Is it harder to include them in group settings — meetings, huddles, brainstorms — compared to one-on-one conversations? Why?
2. Have you seen the team unintentionally exclude them (e.g., talking faster, moving on before they've understood)? Was that noticed or addressed?
3. What would "successful inclusion" look like to you in a team meeting with someone who has a language barrier?

Reaction to the concept (shared robot for group support)

1. If there were a shared device or robot in the room that could help translate or clarify things in real time during team conversations, how do you think that would change the dynamic?
2. Would you feel comfortable relying on it, or would you still want to explain things yourself? Why?
3. Do you think it would reduce the burden on you/the team, or add friction (e.g., slowing down conversation, feeling awkward)?
4. Would you worry it might make the team communicate *at* the tool instead of *with* the person?
5. Could you see it being used to help the team understand cultural or communication norms too, not just language — e.g., tone, directness, idioms?

Trust and practical concerns

1. Since the company would own the device, would you have concerns about how conversations or struggles get logged or reported to management?
2. Do you think the person you work with would actually want to use this, based on what you know of them? Would they feel supported or singled out?
3. What features would make you actually reach for this tool versus just doing it yourself like you do now?

Wrap-up

1. What's one thing you wish you understood better about supporting a coworker with a language barrier?
2. Is there anything about this dynamic that a tool — no matter how well-designed — probably can't fix?

Interview Guide: Employees with a Language Barrier (English as Second Language Speakers)

Warm-up / context

1. Can you walk me through a recent time at work when a language barrier made a task harder than it needed to be?
2. In a typical week, how often do you need help understanding instructions, meetings, or conversations from coworkers?

Current coping strategies

1. Right now, who do you usually turn to when you don't understand something at work? Why that person specifically?
2. Have you ever avoided asking a question or asking for help because of the language barrier? What made you avoid it?
3. What tools (translation apps, notes, gestures, etc.) do you currently use to get by, and how well do they actually work?

Group dynamics / how help currently happens

1. When a coworker helps you understand something, what does that usually look like — do they explain verbally, show you, write it down, use a translator app?
2. Does it feel different asking for help one-on-one versus in a group (e.g., during a team meeting or huddle)? How so?
3. Is there anyone on your team who seems to naturally take on the "helper" role for language issues? What do they do that works?
4. Have you ever felt like you were slowing the group down or that people were impatient? Can you describe that moment?

Reaction to the concept (robot in group settings)

1. If there were a shared device or robot in the room during team conversations that could help translate or clarify things in real time, how do you think that would change how you participate?
2. Would you feel comfortable using it in front of coworkers, or would it feel embarrassing/exposing? Why?
3. Do you think your coworkers would use it to help you, or would they still just explain things themselves like they do now?
4. Is there a difference between the robot helping *you* directly versus the robot helping your *coworkers* explain things to you better? Which would you prefer?

Trust, ownership, and social dynamics

1. Since this device would belong to the company, not to you personally, does that change how you'd feel about using it? (e.g., trust, privacy, feeling watched)
2. Would you worry about the robot creating a record of your language struggles that management could see? Does that concern you?

3. Do you think a tool like this would make your coworkers more patient with you, or could it make them rely on the tool instead of trying to understand you directly?

Impact on relationships

1. Do you think this kind of support would help you build stronger relationships with coworkers, or keep interactions more transactional?
2. Is there anything about your current struggles that you don't think a translation/support tool could actually fix, no matter how good it is?

Wrap-up

1. If you could design one feature into this robot, what would it be?
2. Is there anything about being a non-native speaker at work that we haven't talked about that you think is important for us to understand?